Rich Toward God

Life does not consist in the abundance of our possessions; the wise person is rich toward God, not just rich in things.

Main passage	Luke 12:13-21 (KJV)
Topic	Covetousness
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Life is more than possessions	7 min
Teaching point 2: The rich man's plans left God out	7 min
Teaching point 3: Be rich toward God	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "If you suddenly received a large inheritance, what is the first thing you would do with it?" Let people answer honestly and with humour. Then ask: "How do you think it would change you?" Today Jesus tells a story about a man who had a very good year.

Scripture (3 min)

Luke 12:13-21

13 And one of the company said unto him, Master, speak to my brother, that he divide the inheritance with me. 14 And he said unto him, Man, who made me a judge or a divider over you? 15 And he said unto them, Take heed, and beware of covetousness: for a man’s life consisteth not in the abundance of the things which he possesseth. 16 And he spake a parable unto them, saying, The ground of a certain rich man brought forth plentifully: 17 And he thought within himself, saying, What shall I do, because I have no room where to bestow my fruits? 18 And he said, This will I do: I will pull down my barns, and build greater; and there will I

bestow all my fruits and my goods. [19] And I will say to my soul, Soul, thou hast much goods laid up for many years; take thine ease, eat, drink, and be merry. [20] But God said unto him, Thou fool, this night thy soul shall be required of thee: then whose shall those things be, which thou hast provided? [21] So is he that layeth up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward God.

Read the passage aloud. Ask the class to count how many times the rich man says "I" or "my."

Background (5 min)

A man in the crowd asked Jesus to settle a family dispute over an inheritance. Rabbis were sometimes asked to rule on such questions. Jesus refused to act as judge (v. 14); instead he went to the heart beneath the dispute: greed. "Covetousness" means wanting more, especially what is not ours to have.

The rich man in the parable did nothing illegal. His land produced a bumper crop. His problem was what he planned to do with it, and whom he left out of his plans.

Teaching point 1: Life is more than possessions (7 min)

"Take heed, and beware of covetousness: for a man's life consisteth not in the abundance of the things which he possesseth" (v. 15). Jesus warns against "all" covetousness, every kind. Our culture constantly tells us that the next purchase will satisfy. Jesus says that is a lie. Things cannot fill a soul made for God.

Supporting verses

Luke 12:13-15: And one of the company said unto him, Master, speak to my brother, that he divide the inheritance with me. And he said unto him, Man, who made me a judge or a divider over you? And he said unto them, Take heed, and beware of covetousness: for a man’s life consisteth not in the abundance of the things which he possesseth.

Ecclesiastes 5:10: He that loveth silver shall not be satisfied with silver; nor he that loveth abundance with increase: this is also vanity.

1 Timothy 6:6-10 (read from the Bible)

> *“To imagine that a man's comfort and peace can depend upon temporal things; or to suppose that these can satisfy the wishes of an immortal spirit!”*
>
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 12:20

Handout blanks (answers)

A man's life consisteth not in the abundance of the things which he **possesseth**.

Things cannot fill a soul made for **God**.

Teaching point 2: The rich man's plans left God out (7 min)

In verses 17-19 the rich man talks only to himself. "I" and "my" fill his speech: my fruits, my barns, my goods, my soul. He plans to build bigger barns and then retire to ease. There is no thought of God, no thought of others, no thought of death. JFB lists the reasons Jesus calls him a fool, beginning with this one:

Supporting verses

Luke 12:16-19: And he spake a parable unto them, saying, The ground of a certain rich man brought forth plentifully: And he thought within himself, saying, What shall I do, because I have no room where to bestow my fruits? And he said, This will I do: I will pull down my barns, and build greater; and there will I bestow all my fruits and my goods. And I will say to my soul, Soul, thou hast much goods laid up for many years; take thine ease, eat, drink, and be merry.

James 4:13-15: Go to now, ye that say, To day or to morrow we will go into such a city, and continue there a year, and buy and sell, and get gain: Whereas ye know not what shall be on the morrow. For what is your life? It is even a vapour, that appeareth for a little time, and then vanisheth away. For that ye ought to say, If the Lord will, we shall live, and do this, or that.

Proverbs 27:1: Boast not thyself of to morrow; for thou knowest not what a day may bring forth.

> *"Because he deemed a life of secure and abundant earthly enjoyment the summit of human felicity."*
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 12:16-19

> *"Riches increase thought and perplexity."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 12:17

Handout blanks (answers)

The rich man said, "I will pull down my **barns**, and build greater."

His plans left out God, others, and **death**.

Teaching point 3: Be rich toward God (7 min)

"Thou fool, this night thy soul shall be required of thee." All his planning came to nothing in one night. Then Jesus applies the story: "So is he that layeth up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward God" (v. 21). Being rich toward God means investing our lives and resources in what he values: him, his kingdom, and people in need.

Supporting verses

Luke 12:20-21: But God said unto him, Thou fool, this night thy soul shall be required of thee: then whose shall those things be, which thou hast provided? So is he that layeth up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward God.

Matthew 6:19-21: Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth, where moth and rust doth corrupt, and where thieves break through and steal: But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust doth corrupt, and where thieves do not break through nor steal: For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.

1 Timothy 6:17-19: Charge them that are rich in this world, that they be not highminded, nor trust in uncertain riches, but in the living God, who giveth us richly all things to enjoy; That they do good, that they be rich in good works, ready to distribute, willing to communicate; Laying up in store for themselves a good foundation against the time to come, that they may lay hold on eternal life.

> *"If there is any supreme folly, it is this. As though riches could prolong life, or avert for a moment the approach of pain and death."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 12:20

> *"Acquires riches for his own use--for himself. This is the characteristic of the covetous man."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 12:21

Handout blanks (answers)

Thou fool, this night thy **soul** shall be required of thee.

So is he that layeth up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward **God**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Was it wrong for the man to have a good harvest, or to build barns? What was wrong?

No; the crop was a gift. What was wrong was his self-centred plans, his forgetting of God and others, and his false sense of security.

2. How does our culture encourage covetousness?

Advertising, comparison, social media, the idea that more brings security and happiness.

3. What would it look like in practice to be "rich toward God"?

Generosity, prayerful use of money, investing time in God's kingdom, caring for the poor, contentment.

4. How does remembering that life is short help us fight greed?

It puts possessions in perspective; we cannot take them with us.

Application (3 min)

Take an honest look at your spending and giving this week. Choose one specific way to be "rich toward God": increase a gift, help someone in need, or give away something you do not use. Pray 1 Timothy 6:6: "godliness with contentment is great gain."

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord, everything we have comes from you. Forgive us for trusting in things and for planning our lives without you. Free us from every kind of covetousness. Teach us that life is more than possessions, and make us rich toward you and generous toward others. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 12:20

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 12:16-19

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 12:17

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 12:20

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 12:21

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